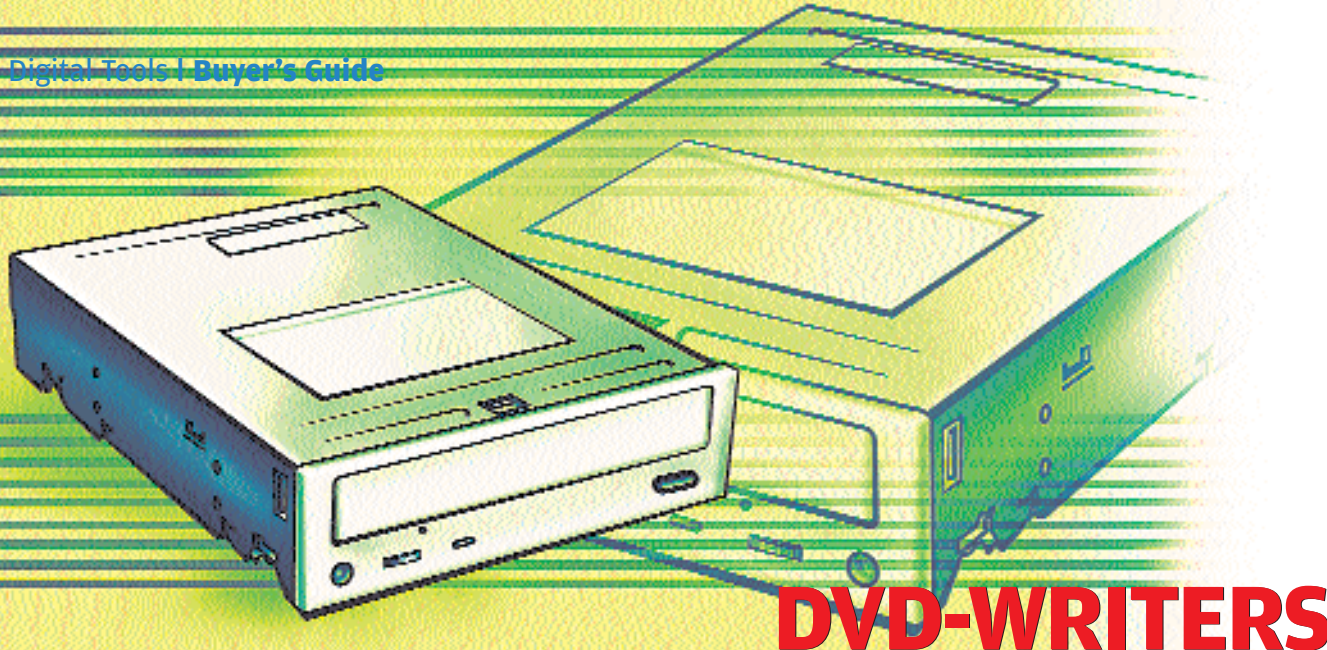




The fastest growing segment in the storage industry today is, without a doubt, the DVD-Writer segment. In fact, they're the best thing to have happened to the storage industry after CD-Writers a few years ago.

DVD-Writers have raised the optical backup capacity of desktop PCs to a minimum of 4.7 GB from the 700 MB of a CD. Users can now create high-res digital video content using DVD-VR technology, which allows the capturing of video to a DVD on the fly.

Though there were a lot of initial compatibility issues between the DVD formats supported by various companies, the differences have since mostly been ironed out.

Questions to ask the dealer

What are the different formats supported by the drive?

Look for drives supporting DVD+R, DVD-R, DVD+RW, DVD-RW, DVD+R DL, and DVD-R DL. An older-generation drive may not support anything double layer, since they existed at a time when DL was only on the drawing board.

What is the form factor of the drive?

Most optical drives today are available in the half-height form factor. Such a drive is much shorter than a traditional full-height drive. Installing such a drive is easier as it fits in almost any cabinet and is less likely to interfere with the motherboard. This also leaves the interior of the PC with more breathing space.

What accessories come bundled?

Many manufacturers bundle writing software with the drive. Some also bundle data cables and bezels.

Usage Tips

❑ Make sure that the PC is not over-clocked before you plan a CD/DVD burning session. Overclocking affects the speed of IDE devices too, and this may lead to the DVD not writing properly.

❑ Some media have capacities above the standard. In order to write to such media, the DVD-Writer as well as the writing software must support overburning.

❑ Videos from a DV-Cam can be captured directly to certain DVD-Writers, but for this, the DVD-Writing software must support the DVD-VR format. This is available on the DVD+R specification, so drives supporting DVD+R can be used for this.

❑ Some DVD-Writer manufacturers specify that certain brands of media may have some problems with their drives. Referring to the DVD-Writer's manufacturer's Web site is a good thing to do.

❑ Check if DMA mode for the drive is enabled in Windows XP. This will enable quicker data transfers at minimal load to the CPU. Instead of a 40-conductor cable, use an 80-conductor one.

❑ Check for firmware updates for your optical drive on the manufacturer's Web site. These can contain bug fixes and address other issues.

Interesting Facts

The analogue optical disk was developed way back in 1958 by David Paul Gregg and it was primarily meant to record video. The Laserdisc standard for movies was later developed from this standard in 1978, and suddenly Laserdisc video players started appearing in the market.



The world saw the launch of the CD drive in 1982, which was a milestone, and the CD drive became a piece of household equipment. DVD players made their appearance in 1996 in Japan and in 1997 in the US. Creative Labs, Diamond Multimedia and Hi-Val released PC DVD-ROM drives bundled with hardware decoder cards in 1997.

The Future

The DVD was thought to be humongous, capable of storing a minimum of 4.7 GB and up to 17 GB of data. As technology manages to squeeze in more and more data into the same dimensions, the hunger for storage space only seems to have increased! This has driven the development of newer standards such as Blu-ray and HD-DVD, which are a hot topic of discussion these days.

Few people doubt that one of these two will dominate the optical disc storage industry in the near future. The only question is, which of the two will it be? It's difficult to say. Refer *The Battle Of The Blue* in this issue for more on HD-DVD and Blu-ray. ■

Points To Ponder

Does my PC meet the minimum system requirements for a DVD-Writer?

A DVD-Writer will work with any PC with a minimum of a 400 MHz processor, 32 MB of RAM, and hard drive space enough to store the data to be written. In addition to this, there should be a free IDE connector, unless

you're buying an external drive.

Should I buy an internal drive or an external drive?

For a home user, an internal drive is the best choice from every angle, be it cost, performance or features. An external drive is useful for people such as PC hardware professionals.